

Algebraic Topology: Study Notes

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Note

These notes present a gradual introduction to algebraic topology, beginning with the fundamental concepts of homotopy and the fundamental group before progressing to more advanced topics as the theory develops. The exposition emphasizes precise definitions, rigorous proofs, motivating examples, and geometric intuition, with the aim of building a coherent understanding of the subject. This is a living document that will be continually revised, expanded, and refined as my study of algebraic topology progresses, with new material, examples, exercises, and references incorporated over time.

Chapter 1

Fundamental Group

The purpose of this chapter is to introduce the fundamental group, one of the central invariants in algebraic topology. We begin by studying paths and homotopies, which naturally lead to the notion of path homotopy. These ideas provide the foundation for defining the fundamental group and exploring its basic properties.

1.1 Homotopy and Path Homotopy

Definition 1.1. Let $f, f' : X \rightarrow Y$ be continuous maps.

We say that f is **homotopic to** f' if there exists a continuous map

$$F : X \times I \longrightarrow Y, \quad I = [0, 1],$$

such that

$$F(x, 0) = f(x), \quad F(x, 1) = f'(x),$$

for every $x \in X$.

- F is called a **homotopy** between f and f' .

- We write

$$f \simeq f'.$$

- If f' is a constant map, then f is called **null-homotopic**.

Geometric Interpretation Think of the parameter $t \in [0, 1]$ as representing time.

- At $t = 0$, the map is f .
- At $t = 1$, the map is f' .
- As t varies continuously from 0 to 1, the homotopy F continuously deforms f into f' .

Definition 1.2. A **path** in X is a continuous map

$$f : [0, 1] \longrightarrow X$$

such that

$$f(0) = x_0, \quad f(1) = x_1.$$

- x_0 is called the **initial point**.

- x_1 is called the **final point**.

Definition 1.3. Let $f, f' : [0, 1] \rightarrow X$ be two paths having the same initial and final points.

They are said to be **path homotopic** if there exists a continuous map

$$F : I \times I \longrightarrow X$$

such that

$$F(s, 0) = f(s), \quad F(s, 1) = f'(s),$$

and

$$F(0, t) = x_0, \quad F(1, t) = x_1,$$

for every $s, t \in I$.

- F is called a **path homotopy** between f and f' .
- We write

$$f \simeq_p f'.$$

Remark 1.4. Homotopy ($\simeq$) is a continuous deformation of one map into another. Path Homotopy ($\simeq_p$) is a continuous deformation of one path into another while keeping the initial and final points fixed throughout the deformation.

Equivalently,

$$\text{Homotopy:} \quad F(s, 0) = f(s), \quad F(s, 1) = f'(s).$$

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Path Homotopy:} \quad F(s, 0) &= f(s), \quad F(s, 1) = f'(s), \\ F(0, t) &= x_0, \quad F(1, t) = x_1. \end{aligned}$$

Thus, in a path homotopy the endpoints remain fixed throughout the deformation.

Remark 1.5 (Pasting Lemma). Let X and Y be topological spaces, and suppose

$$X = A \cup B,$$

where A and B are closed subsets of X .

If

$$f : A \rightarrow Y \quad \text{and} \quad g : B \rightarrow Y$$

are continuous maps such that

$$f(x) = g(x) \quad \forall \quad x \in A \cap B,$$

then the map

$$h : X \rightarrow Y, \quad h(x) := \begin{cases} f(x), & x \in A, \\ g(x), & x \in B, \end{cases}$$

is well-defined and continuous.

Lemma 1.6. The relations $\simeq$ and $\simeq_p$ are equivalence relations.

If f is a path, we denote its path homotopy equivalence class by

$$[f].$$

Proof. We verify the three properties of an equivalence relation.

Reflexivity. Given a map f , define

$$F(x, t) = f(x).$$

Then

$$F(x, 0) = f(x) = F(x, 1),$$

so $f \simeq f$. If f is a path, then F is also a path homotopy, hence

$$f \simeq_p f.$$

Symmetry. Suppose

$$f \simeq f'$$

via a homotopy F . Define

$$G(x, t) = F(x, 1 - t).$$

Then

$$G(x, 0) = f'(x), \quad G(x, 1) = f(x),$$

so

$$f' \simeq f.$$

If F is a path homotopy, then G is also a path homotopy, giving

$$f' \simeq_p f.$$

Transitivity. Suppose

$$f \simeq f' \quad \text{and} \quad f' \simeq f''.$$

Let F be a homotopy from f to f' and F' a homotopy from f' to f'' .

Define

$$G(x, t) = \begin{cases} F(x, 2t), & 0 \leq t \leq \frac{1}{2}, \\ F'(x, 2t - 1), & \frac{1}{2} \leq t \leq 1. \end{cases}$$

Since

$$F(x, 1) = f'(x) = F'(x, 0),$$

the map G is well defined. Since G is continuous on the two closed sets $X \times [0, \frac{1}{2}]$ and $X \times [\frac{1}{2}, 1]$, it is continuous on all of $X \times [0, 1]$, by pasting lemma.

Moreover,

$$G(x, 0) = f(x), \quad G(x, 1) = f''(x),$$

so G is a homotopy between f and f'' . Hence

$$f \simeq f''.$$

If F and F' are path homotopies, then G also fixes the endpoints throughout the deformation. Therefore,

$$f \simeq_p f''.$$

Thus both $\simeq$ and $\simeq_p$ are equivalence relations. $\square$

Example 1.7. Let f and g be any two maps of a space X in $\mathbb{R}^2$. Then f and g are homotopic; the map

$$F(x, t) = (1 - t)f(x) + tg(x)$$

is a homotopy between them called as a **straight-line homotopy** because it moves the point $f(x)$ to the point $g(x)$ along the straight line joining them.

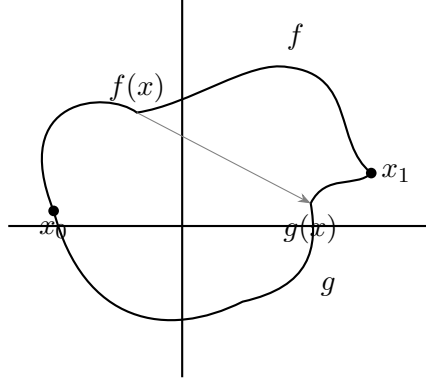


Figure 1.1: Straight-line homotopy between two paths.

Example 1.8. Let A be any convex subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$. Then any two paths f, g in A from x_0 to x_1 are path homotopic in A by the straight-line homotopy F .

Example 1.9. Let

$$X = \mathbb{R}, \quad f(x) = x, \quad g(x) = 2x.$$

A homotopy between f and g is given by the straight-line homotopy

$$H(x, t) = (1 - t)f(x) + tg(x).$$

Substituting f and g , we obtain

$$H(x, t) = (1 - t)x + t(2x) = (1 + t)x.$$

Clearly,

$$H(x, 0) = x = f(x),$$

and

$$H(x, 1) = 2x = g(x).$$

Thus H continuously deforms the map f into the map g .

1.1.1 Product of Paths

Definition 1.10. Let

$$f : I \rightarrow X$$

be a path from x_0 to x_1 , and let

$$g : I \rightarrow X$$

be a path from x_1 to x_2 .

The *product* (or concatenation) of f and g , denoted by

$$f * g,$$

is the path $h : I \rightarrow X$ defined by

$$h(s) = \begin{cases} f(2s), & 0 \leq s \leq \frac{1}{2}, \\ g(2s - 1), & \frac{1}{2} \leq s \leq 1. \end{cases}$$

Since

$$f(1) = x_1 = g(0),$$

the map h is well-defined and continuous (by the Pasting Lemma). Thus h is a path from x_0 to x_2 .

Interpretation. The path $h = f * g$ first traverses the path f (during the first half of the interval $[0, 1]$) and then traverses the path g (during the second half).

The concatenation of paths induces a well-defined operation on path-homotopy classes:

$$[f] * [g] = [f * g].$$

That is, the product of the homotopy classes is the homotopy class of the concatenated path.

To see this, let

$$F : f \simeq_p f'$$

and

$$G : g \simeq_p g'$$

be path homotopies. Define

$$H(s, t) = \begin{cases} F(2s, t), & 0 \leq s \leq \frac{1}{2}, \\ G(2s - 1, t), & \frac{1}{2} \leq s \leq 1. \end{cases}$$

Since

$$F(1, t) = x_1 = G(0, t)$$

for all $t \in I$, H is well-defined and continuous by the Pasting Lemma. Hence,

$$f * g \simeq_p f' * g'.$$

Therefore, the operation $*$ is well-defined on path-homotopy classes.

Remark. The operation $*$ satisfies properties similar to the group axioms. However, $[f] * [g]$ is defined only when

$$f(1) = g(0),$$

so the collection of path-homotopy classes forms a *groupoid* rather than a group.

1.1.2 Properties of the Product Operation

Before analysing the properties of the operation ' $*$ ', we note the following preliminary facts that will be used in the arguments of proofs those properties:

1. If $k : X \rightarrow Y$ is continuous and

$$F : I \times I \longrightarrow X$$

is a path homotopy between the paths f and f' , then

$$k \circ F : I \times I \longrightarrow Y$$

is a path homotopy between the paths $k \circ f$ and $k \circ f'$.

2. If $k : X \rightarrow Y$ is continuous and $f(1) = g(0)$, then

$$k \circ (f * g) = (k \circ f) * (k \circ g).$$

This follows immediately from the definition of the product operation.

3. If $[a, b]$ and $[c, d]$ are two intervals in $\mathbb{R}$, there is a unique map

$$p : [a, b] \longrightarrow [c, d]$$

of the form

$$p(x) = mx + k$$

that carries a to c and b to d , known as the positive linear map of $[a, b]$ to $[c, d]$ because its graph is a straight line with a positive slope. In fact, inverse of such a map and composite of two such maps are again maps of same kind.

With this terminology, the product $f * g$ can be described as follows: On $[0, \frac{1}{2}]$, it equals the positive linear map of $[0, \frac{1}{2}]$ to $[0, 1]$, followed by f ; and on $[\frac{1}{2}, 1]$, it equals the positive linear map of $[\frac{1}{2}, 1]$ to $[0, 1]$, followed by g . In other words, if $\phi : [0, \frac{1}{2}] \longrightarrow [0, 1]$ is a positive linear map, then $f * g$ on $[0, \frac{1}{2}]$ equals the composition $f \circ \phi$; is traversing the same path f but at twice the speed. A similar argument follows for $[\frac{1}{2}, 1]$.

We now verify the three basic properties of the operation $*$.

Associativity.

If $[f] * ([g] * [h])$ is defined, then so is $([f] * [g]) * [h]$, and

$$[f] * ([g] * [h]) = ([f] * [g]) * [h].$$

Proof. Given paths f , g , and h in X , the products $f * (g * g)$ and $(f * g) * h$ are defined precisely when $f(1) = g(0)$ and $g(1) = h(0)$. Now let

$$0 < a < b < 1.$$

Define a path

$$k_{a,b} : I \rightarrow X \text{ as follows:}$$

$k_{a,b}$ equals the positive linear maps of $[0, a]$, $[a, b]$, and $[b, 1]$ to I followed by the paths f , g , and h successively on the intervals $[0, a]$, $[a, b]$, and $[b, 1]$, respectively.

The path $k_{a,b}$ depends on the choice of a and b , but its path-homotopy class does not. Indeed, if

$$0 < c < d < 1,$$

define a piecewise linear map

$$p : I \rightarrow I$$

which maps

$$[0, a] \mapsto [0, c], \quad [a, b] \mapsto [c, d], \quad [b, 1] \mapsto [d, 1]$$

linearly. When restricted to $[0, a]$, $[a, b]$, and $[b, 1]$, respectively, it equals the positive linear map of these intervals onto the intervals $[0, c]$, $[c, d]$, and $[d, 1]$, respectively. Consequently,

$$k_{c,d} \circ p = k_{a,b}$$

Since p is a path in I from 0 to 1, it is path homotopic to the identity map $i : I \rightarrow I$. Hence, there is a path homotopy P in I between p and i . By the first preliminary fact,

$$k_{c,d} \circ p \simeq_p k_{c,d} \circ i.$$

and therefore

$$k_{a,b} \simeq_p k_{c,d}.$$

Now choose

$$a = \frac{1}{2}, \quad b = \frac{3}{4}.$$

Then

$$k_{a,b} = f * (g * h).$$

Similarly, choosing

$$c = \frac{1}{4}, \quad d = \frac{1}{2},$$

gives

$$k_{c,d} = (f * g) * h.$$

Hence these two products are path homotopic. □

The proof above establishes a stronger result: the path-homotopy class of a concatenation is independent of how the interval is subdivided. This is recorded in the following theorem.

Theorem 1.11. *Let f be a path in X , and let*

$$0 = a_0 < a_1 < \cdots < a_n = 1.$$

For each $i = 1, \dots, n$, let $f_i : I \rightarrow X$ be the path that equals the positive linear map of I onto the subinterval $[a_{i-1}, a_i]$ followed by f . Then

$$[f] = [f_1] * [f_2] * \cdots * [f_n].$$

Identity.

Let $e_x : I \rightarrow X$ denote the constant path at x .

If f is a path from x_0 to x_1 , then

$$[f] * [e_{x_1}] = [f], \quad [e_{x_0}] * [f] = [f].$$

Proof. Since the interval I is convex, the identity map $i : I \rightarrow I$ is path homotopic to each of the maps $e_0 * i$ and $i * e_1$. Composing these homotopies with f and using the first two preliminary facts gives

$$f \circ i = f \simeq_p f \circ (i * e_1) = (f \circ i) * (f \circ e_1) = f * e_{x_1},$$

and

$$f \circ i = f \simeq_p f \circ (e_0 * i) = (f \circ e_0) * (f \circ i) = e_{x_0} * f.$$

Hence the corresponding path-homotopy classes are equal. □

Inverse.

Let f be a path from x_0 to x_1 . Define its reverse path by

$$\bar{f}(s) = f(1 - s).$$

Then

$$[f] * [\bar{f}] = [e_{x_0}], \quad [\bar{f}] * [f] = [e_{x_1}].$$

Proof. Note that the inverse of i is $\bar{i}(s) = 1 - s$. Then, $i * \bar{i}$ is a path in I with starting and ending point 0. Because I is convex, there is a path homotopy between e_0 and $i * \bar{i}$. Composing this homotopy with f and using first two preliminary facts to get

$$f \circ e_0 = e_{x_0} \simeq_p f \circ (i * \bar{i}) = (f \circ i) * (f \circ \bar{i}) = f * \bar{f}$$

Similarly, using the fact that $\bar{i} * i$ is path homotopic in I to e_1 , shows that

$$\bar{f} * f \simeq_p e_{x_1}.$$

Therefore,

$$[f] * [\bar{f}] = [e_{x_0}], \quad [\bar{f}] * [f] = [e_{x_1}].$$

□

In conclusion, if we denote by $P(X, x, y)$ the set of all the paths in X from x to y then the quotient set $\frac{P(X, x, y)}{\simeq_p}$ (the set of all path homotopy classes) does not form a group under the operation $*$ defined as

$$[f] * [f'] = [f * f'].$$

But under some restrictions, we can remove this imperfection from it by considering only those paths which are loops; it shall be discussed in next section.

Remark 1.12. Let $h, h' : X \rightarrow Y$ are homotopic and $k, k' : Y \rightarrow Z$ are homotopic; let H, K be the respective homotopies. Define $F : X \times I \rightarrow Z$ as

$$H(x, t) = G(H(x, t), t)$$

. Then F is well-defined and continuous. Also,

$$F(x, 0) = G(H(x, 0), 0) = G(h(x), 0) = k(h(x)) = (k \circ h)(x) \text{ and}$$

$$F(x, 1) = G(H(x, 1), 1) = G(h'(x), 1) = k'(h'(x)) = (k' \circ h')(x)$$

Consequently, $k \circ h \simeq k' \circ h'$.

1.2 The Fundamental Group

In the previous section, we saw that the collection of all path-homotopy classes in a space X does not form a group under the product operation $*$, since the product is defined only when the endpoint of the first path coincides with the initial point of the second.

To overcome this difficulty, we fix a point $x_0 \in X$, called the *base point*, and consider only those paths that both begin and end at x_0 . The set of path-homotopy classes of such loops is closed under the product operation and forms a group, called the *fundamental group* of X .

The fundamental group is one of the most important algebraic invariants in topology. It captures essential information about the shape of a space and remains unchanged under homeomorphisms. Throughout this section, we shall study its construction and establish some of its fundamental properties.

Notation 1.13. We denote the set of all the loops, the paths having same starting and end points, in X at x by $\Omega(X, x)$. That is,

$$\Omega(X, x) = P(X, x, x)$$

Definition 1.14. The set of path homotopy classes of loops based at x_0 , with the operation $*$, is called the **fundamental group** of X relative to the **base point** x_0 . It is denoted by $\pi_1(X, x_0)$. That is,

$$\pi_1(X, x_0) = \frac{\Omega(X, x_0)}{\simeq_p}.$$

Theorem 1.15. $(\pi_1(X, x_0), *)$ is a group.

Proof. It follows immediately from the properties established in the previous section that the operation $*$, when restricted to path-homotopy classes of loops based at x_0 , satisfies the group axioms. Indeed, the product of two loops based at x_0 is again a loop based at x_0 , the constant loop e_{x_0} serves as the identity element, and the reverse of a loop represents its inverse. Thus, $\pi_1(X, x_0)$ forms a group under the operation $*$. $\square$

The group $\pi_1(X, x_0)$ is called the *fundamental group* of X based at x_0 . It is also referred to as the *first homotopy group* of X , since it is the first member of the family of homotopy groups

$$\pi_n(X, x_0), \quad n \geq 1.$$

Example 1.16. Let $\mathbb{R}^n$ denote Euclidean n -space. Then

$$\pi_1(\mathbb{R}^n, x_0)$$

is the trivial group.

Indeed, if f is a loop in $\mathbb{R}^n$ based at x_0 , then the straight-line homotopy between f and the constant loop at x_0 shows that f is null-homotopic. More generally, if X is any convex subset of $\mathbb{R}^n$, then $\pi_1(X, x_0)$ is trivial. In particular, the unit ball

$$B^n = \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n : x_1^2 + \cdots + x_n^2 \leq 1\}$$

has trivial fundamental group.

Definition 1.17. Let α be a path in X from x_0 to x_1 . Define the map

$$\hat{\alpha} : \pi_1(X, x_0) \longrightarrow \pi_1(X, x_1)$$

by

$$\hat{\alpha}([f]) = [\bar{\alpha}] * [f] * [\alpha],$$

where $\bar{\alpha}$ denotes the reverse of α .

The map $\hat{\alpha}$ is well-defined since the operation $*$ is well-defined on path-homotopy classes. Indeed, if f is a loop based at x_0 , then

$$\bar{\alpha} * (f * \alpha)$$

is a loop based at x_1 . Moreover, $\hat{\alpha}$ depends only on the path-homotopy class of α .

Theorem 1.18. The map

$$\hat{\alpha} : \pi_1(X, x_0) \longrightarrow \pi_1(X, x_1)$$

is a group isomorphism.

Proof. To show that $\hat{\alpha}$ is a homomorphism, let $[f], [g] \in \pi_1(X, x_0)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}\hat{\alpha}([f] * [g]) &= [\bar{\alpha}] * ([f] * [g]) * [\alpha] \\ &= ([\bar{\alpha}] * [f] * [\alpha]) * ([\bar{\alpha}] * [g] * [\alpha]) \\ &= \hat{\alpha}([f]) * \hat{\alpha}([g]),\end{aligned}$$

where associativity and the identities

$$[\alpha] * [\bar{\alpha}] = [e_{x_0}], \quad [\bar{\alpha}] * [\alpha] = [e_{x_1}]$$

have been used.

To prove that $\hat{\alpha}$ is an isomorphism, let $\beta = \bar{\alpha}$. Then

$$\hat{\beta} : \pi_1(X, x_1) \longrightarrow \pi_1(X, x_0)$$

is defined by

$$\hat{\beta}([h]) = [\alpha] * [h] * [\bar{\alpha}].$$

For every $[h] \in \pi_1(X, x_1)$,

$$\begin{aligned}\hat{\alpha}(\hat{\beta}([h])) &= [\bar{\alpha}] * ([\alpha] * [h] * [\bar{\alpha}]) * [\alpha] \\ &= [h].\end{aligned}$$

Similarly, for every $[f] \in \pi_1(X, x_0)$,

$$\hat{\beta}(\hat{\alpha}([f])) = [f].$$

Hence,

$$\hat{\beta} = \hat{\alpha}^{-1},$$

and therefore $\hat{\alpha}$ is a group isomorphism. □